A NEW ROADMAP FOR WOMEN'S EMPOWERMENT

From free mobility and safer public spaces to education, health, skills and financial awareness, Andhra Pradesh is building a continuum of support for women and girls across age groups.

Women's empowerment is often measured in terms of schemes launched or benefits delivered. But the more meaningful measure is whether those interventions expand a woman's choices—her ability to travel, study, work, access services, make informed decisions and participate more fully in the economy.

In Andhra Pradesh, the government is pursuing that broader vision through a combination of welfare, mobility, adolescent empowerment and community-based interventions. Two initiatives illustrate the approach: Stree Shakti, which has transformed access to public transport for women, girls and transgender citizens, and Kishori Vikasam, an adolescent empowerment programme designed to equip the next generation with knowledge, skills, confidence and protection.

Together, they represent an important continuum—from creating mobility and opportunity today to preparing young girls for a more empowered tomorrow.

MOBILITY AS EMPOWERMENT

Launched on August 15, 2025, the Stree Shakti Scheme provides free bus travel for women, girls and transgender citizens domiciled in Andhra Pradesh, with valid identification. The facility is available across Pallevelugu, Ultra Pallevelugu, City Ordinary, Metro Express and Express services within the state. Passengers receive Zero Fare Tickets after verification, while the government reimburses APSRTC for the expenditure.

As of August 10, 2026, 86.61 crore women, girls and transgender passengers had availed of the free travel facility, with Zero Fare Tickets amounting to ₹3,079.03 crore. Women's share of total bus travel has risen from 40 per cent to 62 per cent, while daily women ridership has increased from 9.47 lakh to 23.99 lakh.

The impact is visible not only in ridership but also in the overall public transport system. APSRTC's occupancy ratio improved from 69 per cent to 85 per cent, while occupancy in Stree Shakti and Divyang Shakti services reached 93 per cent.

The numbers suggest that affordable mobility is opening up access to education, employment, healthcare, markets and other everyday opportunities for women across the state.

The scale of the response has required APSRTC to adapt its operations. High-demand routes are being monitored and additional services operated. The corporation has augmented 1,413 additional trips per day, adding 64,647 kilometres of operations using the existing fleet. Crew sensitisation and preventive maintenance have also been strengthened to manage the increased demand.

The government has simultaneously focused on basic amenities at bus stations. 113 RO water plants have been provided, while toilet renovation has been sanctioned at 152 bus stations at a cost of ₹24 crore. The addition of 563 fans and 1,802 chairs is also under procurement.

The financial commitment is equally significant. The government reimbursed ₹1,200 crore during 2025-26 and another ₹480 crore up to June 2026 towards the subsidy.

THE GIRL CHILD TAKES CENTRE STAGE

While Stree Shakti addresses access and mobility in the present, Kishori Vikasam focuses on building the capabilities of adolescents aged 11-18.

The Government of Andhra Pradesh's Department of Women Development & Child Welfare (WD&CW) is the nodal department for the programme, working with Health & Family Welfare, School Education, SERP, MA&UD, PR&RD, APSSDC, GSWS and Police. The model is built on inter-departmental convergence, peer learning and service linkages.

Its vision is straightforward: to create a generation of healthy, educated, confident, skilled, informed and responsible adolescents who can make informed decisions, protect themselves from risks and pursue education and livelihood opportunities.

The programme goes well beyond traditional health or education interventions. Its thematic framework covers education continuity, adolescent health, menstrual hygiene, nutrition and anaemia prevention, child protection and POCSO awareness, financial literacy, career guidance, cyber safety, sexual and reproductive health, life skills and substance-abuse prevention.

The objective is to give adolescent girls not merely information, but the ability to use it—to communicate, make decisions, solve problems, develop leadership skills and plan for their futures.

